



metroPLUS

THE HINDU



An India-wide reading community celebrates 10 years of books and bookworms P3

LEO-INSPIRED CAFE IN KASHMIR ATTRACTS TOURISTS P4



Hanu Reddy Farms

Located in Othivakkam near Guduvanchery, Hanu Reddy Raghava Farms is a 70-year-old mango orchard known for its Banganapalli variety, grown from saplings originally sourced from Kadiam in Andhra Pradesh. This year, the farm is seeing a delayed and reduced crop. “The fruiting is not so much because of climate change. It’s

not just our farm, everywhere people are saying the same thing,” says Nirupama Reddy, COO, adding that harvest is expected only towards the end of May.

What sets their produce apart, she says, is their ripening process. “We allow the mangoes to ripen on the tree. So it’s almost 95% mature when we cut it.”

At Hanu Reddy, a mango festival is held every Sunday in June where people can visit the farm, participate in fun activities like pottery and bullock cart ride, shop for mangoes, indulge in a mango feast and more.

The farm sells mangoes through its own outlets and directly from the orchard. To place orders, contact 9884020848.

As a punishing summer reshapes harvest cycles, Chennai’s organic mango sellers navigate delayed seasons, lower yields, and shifting expectations to still bring a diverse, carefully grown crop to the city

For the mango people



Organic Shandy

At The Organic Shandy, founded in 1998 as one of Chennai’s earliest organic marketplaces, this year’s mango season has been marked by unpredictability. “We had some flowering even in February, then it failed. Now they are getting a new flowering, which is very strange,” says co-founder PB Murali, describing what he has observed across their Punnamai Orchard in Cheyyur, which spans 70 acres and houses over 6,000 trees. The farm is currently growing alphonso, Banganapalli, imam pasand and a small quantity of rumani. While the orchard continues to follow its long-standing organic practices, Murali points out that the challenges this year have not been linked to any single cause. He says that only a fraction of trees are in bloom at present.

Beyond the farm, he flags deeper structural gaps in the ecosystem. “We do not have a national mango board in India and there is no wholesaler for organic produce,” he says, noting that organic farmers are often left to navigate both production and distribution on their own. At Organic Shandy, prices are expected to stabilise between ₹70 and ₹100 per kilogram at peak season.

Mangoes can be ordered directly through The Organic Shandy store in Mylapore.



Ponfarm Organic

After two difficult seasons, Ponfarm Organic is expecting a steadier year. “Last two years were bad. We were able to harvest only about three to four tonnes,” says S Ganesh, who runs the seven-acre integrated farm with his family. Unseasonal rain and strong winds had disrupted flowering, but this year, he says, conditions have been more stable and the expected yield is eight to 10 tonnes. The farm grows three varieties: Banganapalli, imam pasand and sendhura, with Banganapalli forming the bulk of the harvest.

For over a decade, Ponfarm has followed organic practices like using panchgavya to ward away pests and monitoring trees closely. Harvesting is staggered rather than done in one go. “We harvest daily after observing the fruits and it yields around 300 to 400 kilograms. Then, we clean and sell it directly.” This also shapes how the fruit is sold and consumed. “We tell customers to buy small quantities as it can be stored only for three to four days.”

To place your orders, reach out to them on WhatsApp via 9884374416. They deliver using local delivery apps.

Organic Farmers Market

At Organic Farmers Market (OFM), the mango season arrives in fragments from different farms, different timelines, and a steady rotation of varieties through the weeks. The shelves typically carry Banganapalli, imam pasand, alphonso and sendhura, alongside native, less common varieties such as kalapadi and jawari, depending on what each farmer is able to supply. As a market that aggregates produce, OFM largely stocks mature, unripe mangoes rather than fully tree-ripened fruit.

“Transporting a ripened mango is very difficult, so we ask farmers to send mature mangoes and customers can control the ripening at home,” he explains. That process, he adds, needs some care. “The sap should not remain and needs to be cleaned properly,” he says. At home, simple methods still work best: wrapping the fruit in paper or cloth, or placing it alongside bananas to speed up the process. “We have to unlearn that everything has to look perfect. That’s not how Nature works,” he says.

Mangoes are available at OFM store in Adyar and OFM markets across the city. Log on to ofm.in to see locations near you.



Cholayil Farm

At Cholayil Farm to Table, variety is the defining feature of the season. Spread across 90 acres with over 2,000 trees, the farm grows close to 20 types of mangoes, including imam pasand, malgova, neelam and kalapadi, along with lesser-seen and region-specific varieties such as suvarnakheela. “We have varieties from all across India. People are more willing now to try different types than just Banganapalli,” says co-founder Susmera Cholayil. While many farms are reporting delays this year, she notes that their cycle has always been slightly offset. “We always anticipate starting only mid-May to end-May,” she says,

adding that the season often stretches well into August.

The farm follows fully organic practices, using a mix of natural inputs such as panchagavya, neem-based solutions and bio compost. “Because we don’t use pesticides or chemical fertilisers to speed up the process, there is that natural delay,” she explains. After crop losses during the cyclone two years ago, this year is expected to be steadier. “We didn’t have that kind of damage this time, so we are expecting a better yield than last year.”

Mangoes are sold at their Anna Nagar store at J block, Anna Nagar East and delivered across the city through local delivery apps.

STEP OUT



Creative collision

Chennai’s independent creative scene comes together for a new festival that moves across music, art, listening sessions, and experimental performances. Conceived by Focus Group Radio, The Angular Festival brings local musicians, visual artists, designers, DJs, and makers into a shared space built around collaboration and discovery. Spread across multiple stages, the event features live bands, electronic acts, installations, an art gallery, and a makers’ market, reflecting the city’s growing appetite for community-led cultural spaces. *The Angular Festival will be held on May 16 from 3pm onwards at The Palomar by Crossway. Tickets priced at ₹1,200 at theangularfestival.com*



Draping taste

An intimate supper club experience built around textiles, conversation, and shared memory invites participants to slow down and engage with food inspired by the sari. Limited to 12 attendees, the evening includes conversations around draping and styling, alongside food and informal interaction. The menu, curated by Chef Goku, will serve dishes like kamba koozh gazpacho with raw mangoes, arisi parupu sadam with Uthukuli butter, thair saadam gelato with prawn thokku, dark chocolate sakara pongal caramel, and more. Photographer Renuka Retnaswamy will document the evening, with a dedicated photo booth space for portraits and candid moments. *For reservations, contact 9952910183.*



Musical brunch

A Sunday brunch at Radio Room brings together live music, familiar film songs, and a relaxed afternoon crowd. Built around classic Tamil favourites, the sing-along session features performances by MJ Shriram, alongside Akhila and Shekar, revisiting songs that continue to resonate across generations of listeners. The format encourages audiences to join in, turning the brunch into a more participatory musical gathering rather than a conventional live performance. As themed dining experiences continue to grow in popularity across the city, events like these are finding a space for nostalgia. *Sing Along Sunday Brunch will be held on May 17 from 12pm to 4pm at Radio Room, Chennai. For reservations, call 8500005672.*



Behind the bar

An evening at Roc-A-Coe invites guests to step behind the bar and understand the craft that shapes a good cocktail. Led by beverage curator, bartender and consultant Karl Fernandes, the session combines storytelling, flavour profiles, and hands-on mixology, giving participants a chance to prepare their own drink while sampling cocktails from Roc-A-Coe’s menu. The experience also includes a welcome cocktail, a digestif, and appetisers served through the evening. *Cocktailology — Learn the Language of Cocktails will be held at Roc-A-Coe, Thousand Lights, Chennai. The two-hour session is open to guests aged 21 and above, with tickets priced from ₹2,000 onwards on district.in*



Once upon a time (Clockwise from left) CP Vishwanath, co-founder Karadi Tales and Karadi Path; The Blue Jackal; and Shobha Viswanath. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



A bear called Karadi

As Karadi Tales turns 30, its founders reflect on the stories, songs and books that have become part of countless childhood memories

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“Why are there no bears in our stories?” Three decades ago, a little boy’s innocent question sparked the birth of what would become one of India’s most beloved children’s storytelling brands. As his parents searched through *Panchatantra* and *Jataka Tales*, they realised that while lions, jackals and monkeys populated Indian folklore, the bear was strangely missing. “Maybe the bear is the one telling all the stories,” came the reply from his parents CP Viswanath and Shobha Viswanath. And thus, Karadi Tales – *karadi* meaning bear in several South Indian languages – was born.

This June, Karadi Tales turns 30, marking a journey that transformed the landscape of Indian children’s publishing. Founded in 1996 by a team of writers, musicians and educators, the Chennai-based publishing house emerged at a time when Indian children’s literature had very few home-grown voices and even fewer Indian stories told with contemporary imagination.

“It really started because we couldn’t find well-told Indian stories for our son after we returned from the US,” recalls co-founder CP Viswanath.



Karadi Tales began at a time when audiobooks for children were virtually unheard of in India. Narayan Parasuram, who led much of the music production, remembers how the format itself was built through experimentation. “We realised that a child would not sit through a flat narration for 25 minutes,” he says. “It had to become a performance – with music, drama and voices.” The audiobooks featured celebrated voices such as Naseeruddin Shah, Girish Karnad and later Gulzar.

Music became central to the Karadi experience. Much of the music was composed by the 3 Brothers and a Violin, the musical collaboration involving Narayan Parasuram, Sriram Parasuram and Viswanath. Classical ragas and Indian rhythmic structures quietly found their way into children’s storytelling.

One of Karadi Tales’ biggest breakthroughs came with Karadi Rhymes, a set of Indian-context nursery rhymes written in English. The rhymes spoke of mangoes, trains, rivers, chai and Indian childhoods. “Many schools may not even realise these are Karadi rhymes any more,” says CP Viswanath. “But the original intention, to create songs rooted in India, has reached children everywhere.”

The Stori Series

Among Karadi Tales’ newer initiatives is the Stori series, a collection of chapter books created in collaboration with the People’s Archive of Rural India (PARI). The series brings stories from rural India to young readers, capturing

everyday lives, communities, traditions and childhoods that rarely find space in mainstream children’s publishing.

The publishing house has also increasingly focussed on inclusivity through tactile books created for visually impaired children. These books combine textured illustrations, Braille and sensory storytelling. For Shobha, whose early years included teaching visually impaired children in Pune, accessibility has always remained an important part of Karadi Tales’ philosophy.

As technology evolved from cassettes to CDs and eventually QR-enabled books, Karadi Tales too has transformed. The shift from audiobooks to picture books happened organically, with the company increasingly collaborating with authors, illustrators and artists.

The picture books have become known for their visual language, incorporating traditional Indian art forms such as Gond, Warli and kalamkari.

Karadi Path

The organisation’s influence later extended into classrooms through Karadi Path, a language-learning initiative that used storytelling, theatre and music-based pedagogy. Several Government schools across India, including collaborations in Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu, adopted the programme.

Recognition has followed consistently over the years. Karadi Tales has won the Jarul Book Award for seven consecutive years, including last year. Internationally too, the company’s books have travelled widely, with publishing rights sold in countries including the US, Sweden, Japan, Turkey and China. The company has also won several international recognitions, including the Audiobook Publisher of the Year award at the London Book Fair International Excellence Awards in 2020.

For its founders, the greatest reward lies elsewhere. “A whole generation has grown up on Karadi Tales,” says Shobha. “And now a new generation is discovering these stories again. That continuity means everything to us.”

Tradition packed in games

Kreeda, in collaboration with Kamala, reintroduces Indian tradition through games and crafts in A Summer Journey in India

Diya Vakada

In a country that is rich in tradition, remembering where we have come from becomes increasingly important. Reconnecting with our roots however, need not be tedious or a chore – it could be done through a session of games and storytelling. A Summer Journey in India, an initiative by Kreeda and Kamala, two Chennai brands, is a weekly programme in the city that shines light on Indian culture through traditional games, crafts, and stories.

Kreeda, an organisation dedicated to reviving traditional Indian games, is holding weekly sessions in collaboration with Kamala – the Crafts Shop of the Crafts Council of India.

Held every Saturday in May, each week focusses on a different State by looking at the traditions and games that make them unique. The first session kicked off on May 9 and focussed on Telangana and Andhra Pradesh.

The session featured music by Carnatic vocalist and Sangeetha Kalanidhi recipient, S Sowmya, and a variety of games that showcased the heritage of the chosen states. People were seated on mats, trying to arrange pebbles in rows of three for the game dahdi. Or playing vaikuntapali, a traditional game from Andhra Pradesh similar to snakes and ladders.

Rather than holding on to



All play A series of traditional games by Kreeda will now be played at Kamala The Crafts Shop all month long. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

heritage for the sake of nostalgia, the focus of the sessions is to bring generations together in order to engage with Indian culture.

Traditional games are available to play, and they are accompanied by visuals and regional crafts connected to the chosen State. In the weeks to come, Vinita Sidhartha, founder, Kreeda will helm the event.

“A person might not know about the traditions that come from areas in Andhra,” says Vinita, reflecting after the conclusion of the first session. “We can build awareness for everyone to understand and appreciate. It’s a wonderful window into our cultural events.”

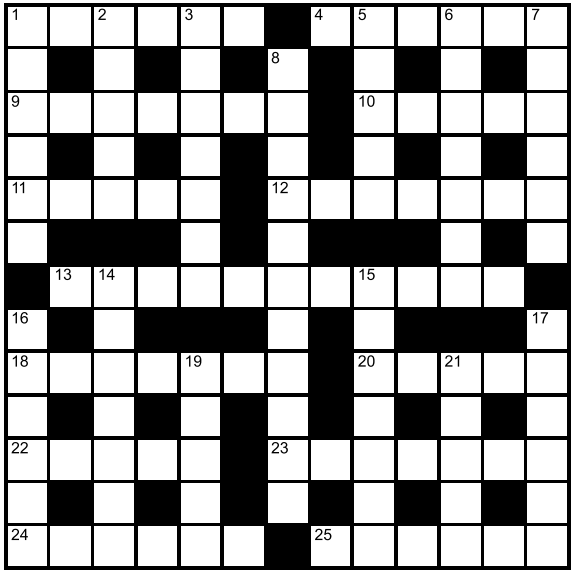
On May 16, attendees will attempt an exploration of Odisha accompanied by a conversation

with historian Chitra Madhavan. After that, there will be a stop in Karnataka where the culture of the State will be revealed by historian V Sriram. Finally, the last destination of the month is Tamil Nadu with author-historian Pradeep Chakravarthy.

“There is something for everyone to take away,” says Vinita. “Not just for adults, but the children too would listen when they heard the music playing or when the talks began. Then of course, they would go back to being engrossed in the games.”

A Summer Journey in India will be held every Saturday in May, between 10.30am and 12.30pm, at Kamala - The Crafts Shop, Royapettah. To register contact 9840700445.

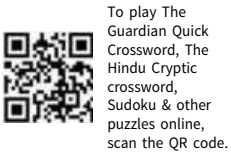
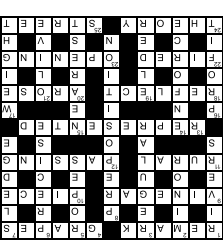
QUICK CROSSWORD #53 (Set by Doppelganger)



Across

- 1 Comment (6)
- 4 Used to make wine (6)
- 9 Dilute impure acetic acid (7)
- 10 Fragment (5)
- 11 Countryside (5)
- 12 Moving by (7)
- 13 Portrayed (11)
- 18 Think seriously (7)
- 20 Woke up (5)
- 22 Dismissed (5)
- 23 A gap (7)
- 24 Explanation (6)
- 25 Avenue (6)

Solution No. 53



To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

Down

- 1 Natural streams (6)
- 2 Not yet an adult (5)
- 3 Customary (7)
- 5 Cables (5)
- 6 Exact (7)
- 7 Vehicle mounted on runners (6)
- 8 Word usually preceding a noun (11)
- 14 Compel observance (7)
- 15 Just about (7)
- 16 Advantageous gain (6)
- 17 Measurement of mass (6)
- 19 Greater in seniority (5)
- 21 Mediterranean evergreen tree (5)

House by the cerulean sea

At Isai Karai, a cosy bungalow retreat by the beach, it feels like staying at your grandparents’ house

Priyadarshini Paitandy
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Turn off that alarm. At Isai Karai, you are woken up by chatty birds, bright sunlight, and the excitement of what breakfast will be.

The new property by CGH Earth Saha, about 10 kilometres from central Mamallapuram, is tucked away in the midst of greenery, and about 150 metres from the beach. The sounds of the sea, and the breeze that rustles leaves, makes your body let loose, shoulders relax, jaws unclench, and calms the mind.

“As travel preferences evolved, we noticed a growing inclination towards intimate holiday spaces that offer greater privacy yet personalised service, and thoughtfully curated experiences. In response to this shift – and guided by the ethos of CGH Earth – Saha was conceived,” explains George Joseph, vice president, Operations, CGH Earth. These include heritage villas steeped in history, and serene bungalow retreats.



Spread across half an acre, Isai Karai is a collaboration between the owner Mahitha Ravilla and CGH Earth that oversees and curates the hospitality experience. The 50-year-old property comprises Vasunthara villa with three rooms and a dining and living area, with the two Kurumba cottages adjacent to it offering more privacy.

Each room is designed differently. Some have open-to-sky showers. A wrap-around terrace runs

along mine. Inside, are two diwans by the windows, and a four poster bed so high that there is a footstool to climb onto it. The interiors at Isai Karai are an ode to Mamallapuram’s art and cultural heritage. The rooms are awash with vibrant paintings and stone sculptures that reflect this town’s centuries-old stone carving tradition. “The house has retained most of its original charm, with only a few thoughtful updates to enhance

comfort and functionality. Every painting and artefact has been chosen by Mahitha, making the home a reflection of her aesthetic sensibilities,” says George.

As I make my way through the bright living room to the kitchen, Kavitha Vignesh, the efficient, cheerful villa manager greets me warmly with a platter of cheese, dried fruits and a plateful of cut watermelon, bananas, and papaya. “The papaya is from our garden,” she beams as she



Check in, bliss out (Clockwise from left) Interiors of one of the Kurumba cottages; a room in the main bungalow; and breakfast at Isai Karai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

takes us on a quick tour while breakfast is prepared. There are mango, papaya, mulberry, star fruit, Chinese orange, gooseberry, sapodilla, and guava trees. Here, there is no menu to order from. The meals are cooked fresh with local produce; simple flavours that are resolutely South Indian. The kitchen staff also rework the menu to your requirements.



In the mornings, one can hear a purposeful telephonic conversation between the kitchen staff and fishermen on the fresh catch of the day. “Today we have *vanjaram*, squid, and red snapper,” says Kavitha.as she brings us glasses of chilled *panakkam*.

The property is great for lazing, soaking in Nature, reading, and enjoying me-time but what it also aims to do is acquaint clients with Mamallapuram and activities like surfing that have become popular here along the ECR.

Our first stop is, what our local guide Dileep calls, the sculpture hub of Mamallapuram. The sounds of chisels and electric drills fill the air and fine granite powder floats around us. “There are more than 200 carving units here,” he explains. These artisans go abroad to make sculptures, often commissioned by

the Indian communities there, says Dileep.

I was five when I first saw Mamallapuram’s ancient stone monolithic wonders. My father made me pose against Arjuna’s Penance, Pancha Rathas, and the Shore Temple. Each shot well mulled over to do justice to the 36 pictures the 35mm roll permitted. This time around, I am armed with a phone camera and take multiple shots, especially of Krishna’s Butterball and the sun behind the Shore Temple.

Among the more recent highlights to check out are the India Seashell Museum, started by Raja Mohamed and the lighthouse built in the early 1900s. I head back to Isai Karai for a picnic on the beach: cosy chairs a table laden with fresh watermelon juice, bajji, and a tiered dessert stand with orange cake (made from oranges in the garden), fruits and cookies.

In the evening, post a swim in the pool, I am treated to a barbecue dinner. Seafood and chicken with grilled pineapple hit the spot. Dessert is banana flambe and ice cream which I tuck into at the porch, lazing on a plantation chair, enjoying slow living and the sound of silence.

CGH Earth Saha Isai Karai is located at 67/28 B, East Coast Road, Krishnan Karanai Village, Nemmeli. Tariff starts at ₹10,000.



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The year was 2016. An anonymous Facebook user formed a book club community to bring together readers across the country and the The Broke Bibliophiles (BB) was born. This community of readers, currently present in various cities across India, is celebrating its 10th anniversary this year. Solomon Manoj, founder of the Chennai chapter of the club, says that the decision of readers to come together for this club was initiated by a Facebook user who posted book deals and discounts on their page and remains evasive about their identity till date. Nirav Mehta, curator of the Mumbai chapter, in an email response, says, “The first meetup in 2016 was honestly just an experiment. No big vision, no long-term plan. Just a bunch of people showing up with books and curiosity. If anything, I thought it might fizzle out in a few months like most things on the Internet do”. Today, the club in Chennai has between 15 and 20 people attending their meets that are held twice a month. “We don’t have age restrictions. Some of the members bring in their children who are about 11. So, members will range anywhere

A decade-old bookmark

The Broke Bibliophiles book club, founded in 2016, celebrates its 10th anniversary with readers across India

between 11 and the mid 40s”, Solomon says. With a theme for every month, the club chooses books through a vote. “We just had our April co-read discussion where we read a Tamil book: *Huntsman* by Lakshmi Saravanakumar. Our theme was translation”. In fact, it was Sudharsan H, 36, a product manager in the city and an active member of the club since 2016 who recommended the book. Sudharsan, who had always been active in book communities of Tamil literature, found a welcome space in the Broke Bibliophiles. For someone who was not confident in the English language, the club made him feel included. “The club is very inclusive and democratic”, he says.

A strictly hobby club that requires no membership fee, the BB Chennai chapter saw a significant shift when the Covid pandemic hit and the meets went online. Solomon says that while there was no significant change in the number of people in attendance, people preferred offline meets. Nirav agrees and says that

The first meetup in 2016 was honestly just an experiment. Just a bunch of people showing up with books and curiosity

NIRAV MEHTA
Curator, Mumbai chapter

Covid was a real disruption. “We tried going online, but it never quite felt the same. What did happen though, is that people realised how much they valued these offline spaces,” he says. On the club taking no membership fee, he adds, “The moment you add a fee, you change the equation. This way, anyone can walk in, students, working professionals, first-time readers and feel like they belong. It keeps things democratic, a little chaotic sometimes, but very real”. Solomon also says, “The reading scene in Chennai is actually thriving. I think in the past few years it has become even more visible because of the advent of social media. I think the book club provides an avenue for people to come together as a community and talk about their passions.” Deepthy Bharath, 37, agrees. She says that it is difficult to meet people, especially, like-minded ones at her age. A member of the book club in Chennai for more than two years, she says clubs like these are a safe space and provide a sense of community. “Nobody is dumbing down the other and there is a sense of emotional and intellectual intimacy”, she says. The club is currently active in four cities – Chennai, Bengaluru, Delhi, and Mumbai and meet in different cafes each week.

New chapter
Members of the Broke Bibliophiles community which has consistently seen about 15 to 20 members show up at every meet over the span of 10 years. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The new age kitchen

As home cooks experiment with global cuisine, Origin Fresh bets on speciality produce

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“W here to find galangal in Chennai.” “Thai bird’s eye chilli near me.” These were some of my recent Google searches on a weekend when I found myself craving Thai curry the way I had eaten it on a trip to Bangkok. I quickly realised this little weekend project was harder than expected because the ingredients were simply not easy to find. For all the convenience promised by modern grocery apps, finding anything beyond the familiar still feels surprisingly difficult. Home cooking has changed dramatically over the last few years. Post-pandemic kitchens have become more experimental, with people attempting ramen broths, Korean stews, pasta sauces, and Thai curries with a seriousness once reserved for restaurant kitchens. This is the shift in food culture that Origin Fresh is betting on. The Bengaluru-based fresh produce platform, which recently opened its second Chennai outlet in Anna Nagar, is positioning itself less as a quick commerce platform and more as a specialist for fruits, vegetables and hard-to-find ingredients. “We are not a 10-minute delivery platform because that is not our strength,” says Prashanth Vasanth, CEO and co-founder of Origin Fresh. “Our strength is sourcing and growing high-quality fruits and vegetables.” Started in 2024 by Prashanth and his co-founder Vikram (whose family has been in the fruits and vegetables business for decades), Origin Fresh began with a simple question: how do you make ingredients usually limited to restaurant kitchens accessible to home cooks? “People are well-travelled now, especially after Covid. They are exposed to new cuisines and they

want to recreate those dishes at home,” says Prashanth. “But the problem we saw was that many of those ingredients were simply not available. We wanted to make those ingredients more accessible to consumers. That is how Origin Fresh started.” Today, the platform works with more than 5,000 micro farmers growing everything from staples to hydroponic lettuces, jalapeños, bird’s eye chillies and nearly a dozen varieties of tomatoes. Its shelves now carry produce rarely seen in regular neighbourhood grocery stores from beefsteak tomatoes and shiso leaves to Thai guavas, hydro kale and Japanese honeydew melons. Unlike most delivery-first grocery platforms, Origin’s stores double up as fulfilment centres, allowing for what Prashanth calls a “last-mile quality check” before produce reaches customers. The platform currently works with farms across Malur, Chikkaballapur, Ooty and Nashik, following a “picked today, delivered tomorrow” model. “Vegetables won’t be 100% right every single time,” says Prashanth. “The shelf life in India is very different from what you see abroad. But what we are trying to do is make people discover new varieties and enjoy cooking again.” What Origin Fresh appears to be responding to is a subtle but growing shift in urban food habits. Ingredients once confined to restaurant kitchens or imported grocery aisles are slowly entering everyday cooking conversations. For a growing number of home cooks, groceries are no longer just about utility, but about experimentation, memory and curiosity.

Origin Fresh is now at 1st Avenue, RV Nagar, Block I, Annanagar East, Chennai. The store is open from 6.30am to 10.30pm. Produce can also be purchased from the app.



Farm to table Cherry tomatoes growing at a farm for Origin Fresh. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Last week, I ate 20-plus dishes from different parts of the country in a single meal. No, this was not a buffet at a star restaurant, but an intimate meal at someone’s home in Chennai. We have seen kitty parties, apartment communities hosting potlucks, and people hosting friends for a meal. These community-driven social gatherings are a great way to not just learn and enjoy varied cuisines but are becoming central to the way people make new friends in the real world. These are the thoughts that went into the creation of The Shared Table, a monthly potluck that brings together Chennai’s many home cooks who run cloud kitchens. The brainchild of Yogita Uchil – who helms the food revival project Soul on a Plate and digital community, Eat Pray Love – it kickstarted in March and now brings together 20 cooks. The task is simple. Bring a dish you have grown up eating: seasonal, nostalgic, deeply personal. Gracing the community table were Punjabi kadhi pakora, Nellai sodhi with inji thuvayal from South Tamil Nadu, Bengali mutton gravy; Gujarati thepla and aam sabji, Rajasthani bhedmi roti with gatke ki sabzi and ker saangri, Bohri white sauce chicken cutlets, Chettinad kavuni arsi



Dishing it out Home chefs at The Shared Table. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



the last potluck, and in the kitchen, a few others exchange food souvenirs: putt u podi from Sri Lanka, and masalas from home. Yogita adds that the initiative also stems from wanting everyone to meet outside of the WhatsApp and Instagram communities. “Most women cook for their families and it is appreciated by their family members. Here, we all appreciate the food and are thankful to each other. That is a motivation for women who cook everyday: recognition.” Nisreen Mustafa Madraswala, a French teacher by profession who also specialises in gut health brings her Bohri specialities to the group. “I am also a part of the Rotary Club, and have been a part of Dining for a Cause. I have made so many friends through this community and this potluck is different from meeting up in a restaurant. It feels personal,” says Nisreen, who brought the traditional Bohri nariyal paak (coconut barfi). So the next time you are looking for a taste of India’s culinary diversity, you know where to head. If you would like to be part of the next potluck, reach out to @soulonaplatebyeat prayandlove on Instagram

Community on a plate

From Rajasthani ker sangri to Chettinad desserts, a monthly potluck brings home chefs together to share regional cuisines

icecream, and a Sri Lankan milkmaid jelly pudding, to name a few. “Through Soul on a Plate, I am able to give an opportunity to these home chefs to showcase their talent, but at times, for reasons beyond control, a few don’t get an opportunity to take their food on a public platform. The Shared Table is a way for everyone to present their food in a fun and relaxed environment,” says Yogita, who also launched Dining for a

Cause last year, an initiative wherein people are brought together to visit and support not-for-profit restaurants in Chennai. For Divya Anund who runs The OG Paratha, The Shared Table is about more than just the food. “Despite everyone being home chefs and culinary entrepreneurs, there is no competition but a sense of camaraderie. This platform also helps break stereotypes about the cuisines we

represent. For example, Punjabi cuisine is more than just its tikkas and dal makhani. We have rajma, vadi aloo, and so much more,” says Divya, who brought an earthen pot of warm, aromatic kadhi pakora. In a corner, two women recall the delicious prawn curry savoured at



mango chilli margarita. The menu is currently available across Ciclo outlets in Chennai through the season.



dolls and food products. @Arulmurugan Towers, 200 Feet Radial Road. Until May 17 from 11am to 9pm.

Take your pick

Kalaa Utsavam, a handicraft and handloom exhibition by Faboo events, features over 100 stalls with handloom saris, jewellery, home decor, antique pieces, toys, footwear, terracotta



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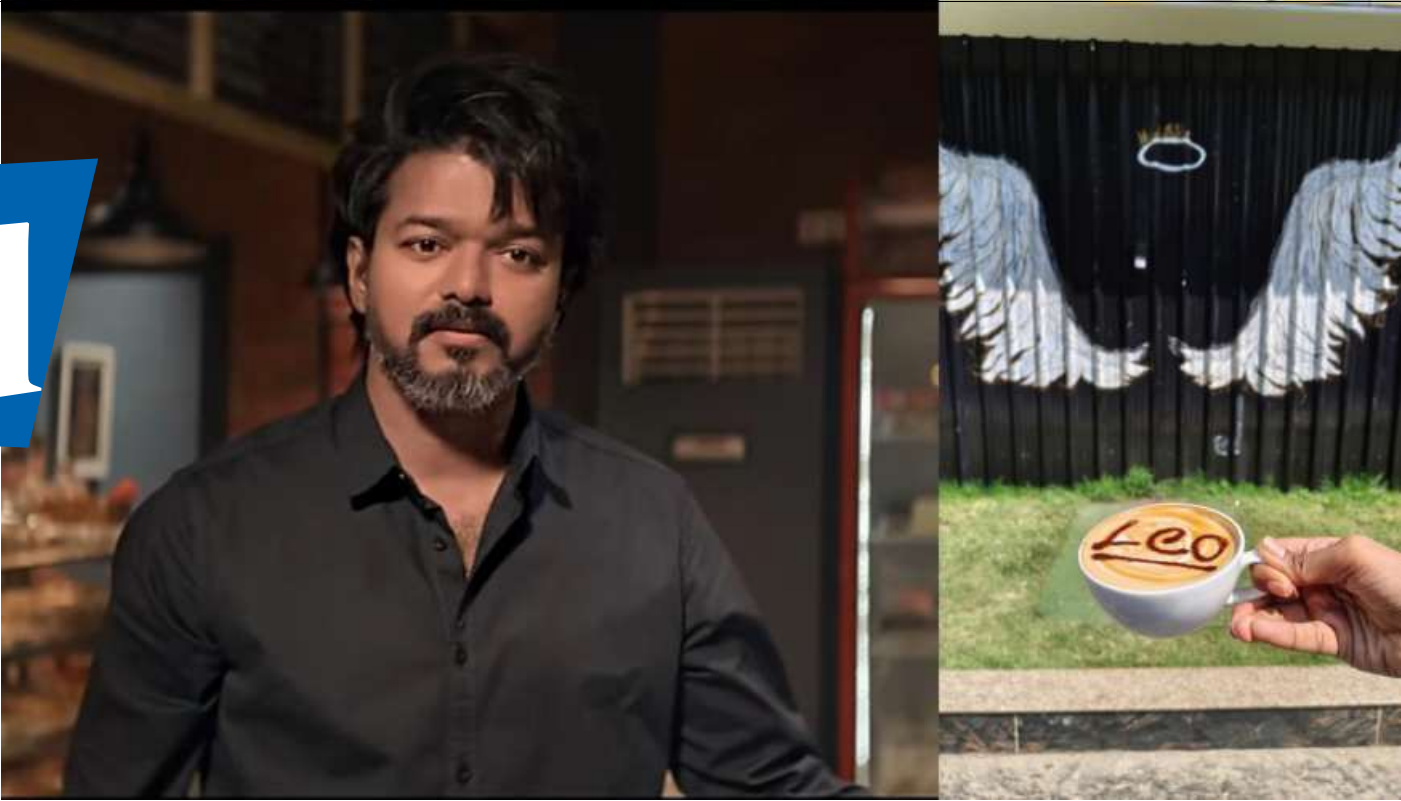
Leo and behold

Tamil Nadu tourists are flocking to this cafe in Kashmir, where Chief Minister Vijay’s *Leo* was shot

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If you walk into Sifar Cafe in Anantnag district, 40 kilometres from Pahalgam in South Kashmir, it is guaranteed that you would run into at least one Tamil person shooting an Instagram reel besides posters of Tamil Nadu’s newly elected Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay. What role does Vijay play in Anantnag, an area that was

once known to be among the most militant zones in Kashmir? Sifar, an unassuming cafe started in 2021, is now a prominent tourist spot for any Tamil cinema enthusiast who visits because it is the exact location where the film *Leo* (2023) starring Vijay was shot. Here, he dons the role of a secret gangster, leading a double-life as a cafe owner in a serene snow-covered setting. In the film, Vijay pulls shots of espresso, feeds his on-screen wife Trisha cake, fights an evil Sandy master, and meets his



Reel effect Vijay from *Leo* inside Sifar cafe in Kashmir, and a chocolate coffee from the menu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

in 2022 and looked at the location. The portion at the cafe was shot for 25 days even though the initial agreement was 22 days. I have been working here since the beginning and have served Vijay sir many helpings of the trout fish, a famous local fish here. He would be quiet and usually be at the caravan.” Since 2023, the team at the cafe seems to have piggy-backed on the success of the film. They now have pictures of Vijay and Sanjay Dutt spread all over the indoor and outdoor areas that seat 170 people; the famous chocolate coffee (30ml espresso, chocolate syrup, milk and foam) on the menu; and an LED screen that frequently plays scenes from the movie. “It is nice to see them be so fond of a cine star. I am proud to have served a leader like him,” Shaukat says.

Sifar Cafe is on KP Road (Khanabal-Pahalgam Road), Bortzoo, Anantnag, Jammu and Kashmir, 191215.

delinquent father, Sanjay Dutt there. During my visit to the establishment called Cafe Wild Beans in the film, I run into a Chennai-based pastor and his friends who danced the hook steps of the song ‘Naa Ready’ from the film as soon as they arrived. They waste no time in pulling their phones out to click pictures of Vijay, and are jubilant to be at the same

location where their beloved leader once bashed up the bad guys. Another six-year-old has apparently heard songs from the unreleased film *Jana Nayagan* on repeat while enroute to the place. “In the last week since ‘Thalapathy’ Vijay was elected as Chief Minister, 90% of the people who have visited have been from Tamil Nadu. But we get fans from Kerala and North

India too. On the day they arrive in Kashmir, most tourists tell their drivers to head to Sifar. They arrive here and want only one thing: Chocolate Coffee,” says Nadeem Bhat, an employee at the cafe. The drink is exactly what Helson Vishal, a priest from Tondiarpet, will be ordering too. “This is a true fan moment for all of us who have travelled

to Kashmir, especially in the wake of Vijay sir becoming the Chief Minister. The most famous dialogue from the film is ‘Chocolate Coffee’. I want to taste it,” he says. At the cafe, Shaukat Rahman, a floor manager, says that tourists regularly ask the service staff what he was like when the film was shot. “I tell them about how some scouts came from Tamil Nadu

STRINGS ATTACHED

Meet Ramana Balachandran, the Tiruvannamalai-based Carnatic musician behind the viral *Dhurandhar* veena hook

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A classical veena interlude in *Dhurandhar* is making waves. Featured in singer Arijit Singh’s ‘Phir Se’ track in the recent Bollywood superhit starring Ranveer Singh, this zingy instrumental bit is being recreated on social in Reels and is receiving praise. The man behind the interlude is Tiruvannamalai-based Ramana Balachandran, a fast-rising musician who is already popular in Chennai’s *kutcheri* circuit. “It happened quite serendipitously,” recalls Ramana, “Shashwat bhai (music director) had been following my work on Instagram, and we connected through a common friend. The *Dhurandhar* team was warm, and asked me to keep in mind that it was a bittersweet situation. It was nice to get the freedom to express myself musically... but we had no idea that it would blow up so much.” For Ramana, a musician who has largely avoided film work despite offers coming his way, the *Dhurandhar* outing has

catapulted him to the national stage. “To see such a short interlude resonating with a variety of backgrounds gave me joy. I’m very interested in technical aspects of recording and mixing; in fact, for my veena interlude, the microphone was kept 2.5 feet above the instrument, which gave a different kind of sound that was new to me.” This young musician’s story starts off in Bengaluru, where he

To see such a short veena interlude in *Dhurandhar* resonating with listeners from various backgrounds gave me a lot of joy. People are making covers and reels of it

RAMANA BALACHANDRAN
Musician



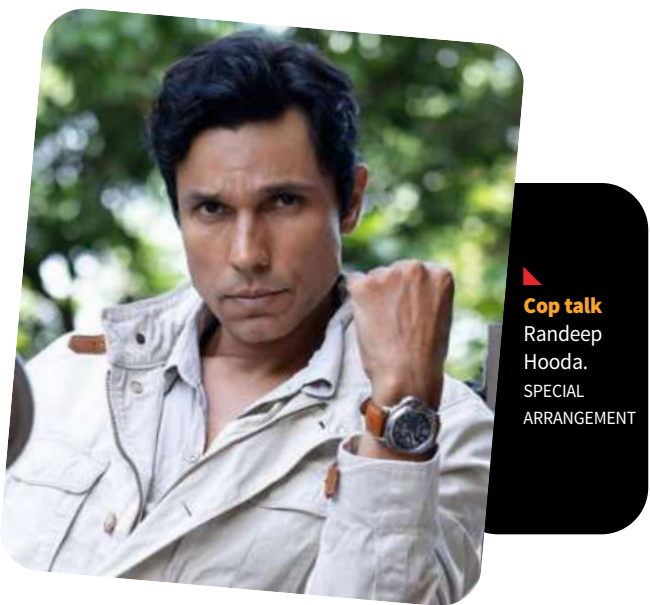
grew up, to parents who were both passionate about music. The big turning point came when he was nine when a young Ramana caught an error when his mother, Sharanya, was playing the veena. “She was playing ‘Saadhinchane’ (one of the five celebrated Pancharatna Kritis of Saint Thyagaraja),” he recalls, “I kept telling her that she was getting one particular phrase wrong, though I couldn’t play it myself.” That particular comment from her young child made the mother sit up and take notice. Soon, Ramana was put in veena classes – under B Nagalakshmi – and he made rapid strides in it, even as he juggled mridangam sessions, vocal classes and school.

In between all these rapid changes, the Ramana household moved lock, stock and barrel from Bengaluru to Tiruvannamalai, a decision that impacted his cultural and musical understanding. In Tiruvannamalai, even as he was home-schooled, Ramana’s life became more about music and spirituality. “Here, we see so many people who have renounced luxurious lives and doing such quality work, without making a big fuss about it. Watching all that close quarters deeply inspired me.”

Tales from the track Today, Ramana is extremely comfortable in a classical music space, but is still taking baby steps in the film music space. “In film music, there is a huge emphasis on emotive appeal, which may or may not exist in classical music.” Currently, the 24-year-old is on a mission: to package classical music and make it more accessible. “My priority is not films, because I am first and foremost a Carnatic vainika, and I feel there is an ocean of work here to delve into.”

Breaking the fourth wall

Actor Randeep Hooda, along with filmmaker Neeraj Pathak, opens up on *Inspector Avinash*



Cop talk Randeep Hooda, along with filmmaker Neeraj Pathak, opens up on *Inspector Avinash*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Randeep Hooda gets back in uniform as his pulpy crime-thriller series, *Inspector Avinash*, is coming up with season 2. The actor has played a cop multiple times before – whether it is in a period-drama flair in *Once Upon A Time In Mumbai* (2010), a relentless edginess in *Jannat 2* (2011) or while chasing a superstar in *Kick* (2014). So, he wasn’t too keen when filmmaker Neeraj Pathak approached him to headline *Inspector Avinash*. “I told him that I don’t want to hear a cop script, as I was getting too many of those. But then he told me the story, I was quite bowled over,” says Randeep, as he opens up on his choices. “Between what you choose and what chooses you, lies your career. I just try to select whatever it is that fascinates me in that particular moment.” It is somewhat easy for the actor to determine if he would work on a project or not. “During the script narration, I should be able to listen to it with interest and imagine the world. The story should also have a

shade of something that I have not done before,” he says, adding that he has been considering other aspects beyond these lately. “It is important to know who is producing it, how it is going to be exhibited and where, because a lot of hard work can go unnoticed if it’s not for the right platform,” says Randeep. Inspired by the real-life story of Uttar Pradesh’s super-cop, Avinash Mishra, *Inspector Avinash* is set in the 1990s, where he battles sinister gang lords of weapon cartels along with his newly formed Special Task Force (STF). Despite exploring gritty themes and featuring some violent action sequences, the show’s overall tone is balanced with the humorous appeal of Avinash. On various occasions, he breaks the fourth wall and addresses the camera, sharing his thoughts directly to the audience – something the other characters cannot hear. Neeraj explains that he inculcated the technique in order to build a parallel narrative alongside the cases which Avinash solves. “I didn’t want to use voice-overs where he is heard telling his story over other visuals. Instead, I thought of some punchy one-liners that he can deliver directly to the camera to

grab everyone’s attention. It was written carefully to have that effect. Many people told me that they would wait for these one-to-one addresses,” says Neeraj. However, Randeep wasn’t too convinced with it in the beginning. “I had only seen it in *House of Cards*. I wasn’t too sure how it would pan out here. But when I faced the camera for the first time and delivered my lines, I enjoyed doing it and felt that it was possible. It’s good that I wasn’t able to influence Neeraj,” Randeep smiles. Through the dramatic action and dialogue, Neeraj instils an entertaining factor to the series, which feels slightly different from a host of other crime-thrillers set in the heartland. “When I was writing the show, most of the crime dramas coming on OTT were realistic slow burners and had an entirely different grammar. But I wanted to bring in the aesthetics of commercial cinema on OTT. It is a huge challenge to reach the last level of audience and I always want to do that,” says the filmmaker.

Inspector Avinash season 2 will be releasing on JioHotstar on May 15



The boy arrives Malayalam filmmaker Chidambaram’s third film, *Balan The Boy*, is set to release worldwide on June 19. The film will release in Malayalam, Hindi, Telugu, Tamil and Kannada. Written by Chidambaram and writer-director Jithu Madhavan, *Balan The Boy* is expected to be a story about identity and a sense of belonging. The film is also slated to be screened at the Marché Du Film at the Cannes Film Festival 2026. Chidambaram’s last directorial, *Manjummel Boys* was the first Malayalam film to collect ₹200 crore at the box office across the world, according to the Film Exhibitors’ United Organisation of Kerala (FEUOK).

A different note Ramana Balachandran; (above) a still from *Dhurandhar*. THAMODHARAN B

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